

Chapter 97_3 - Impropriety

After a long time, two maggots seemed to crawl out of the two bloody holes that were its eyes. Then it turned its body and went deeper.

After that "person" left, Ning Fuyi's sharp eyes caught sight of a small copper lock that had fallen at her feet. She bent down to pick it up and, by the light of the fire starter on the ground, clearly saw the words "Shumei" engraved on it.

"Calm down," Ning Fuyi reached out to pull up Qin Xiaoran, who was rolling on the ground, and stuffed the copper lock in front of his tear-stained face. "Do you know who this person is?"

Qin Xiaoran was still screaming with his mouth open. As he screamed, he saw the words on it, and his cries became hoarse.

"Ah ah ah... Shumei?" Qin Xiaoran wiped his tears and snot as he took the copper lock, breathing heavily with lingering fear. "This, this name sounds very familiar."

At this time, Su Mo had also overcome her terror and slowly walked to Ning Fuyi's side. After Ning Fuyi looked at her, she raised her hand: "I'm fine."

Ning Fuyi nodded and looked at Qin Xiaoran, who was frowning in thought, temporarily forgetting his fear.

"I remember now!" Qin Xiaoran clutched the ash-covered wall and stood up. "Previously, when I was punished to kneel in the ancestral hall, I saw it on the memorial tablets. At that time, I was puzzled - these ancestral memorial tablets had always only allowed men from the clan to enter, so why was there a woman's name? Moreover, that tablet had three layers of chains hanging from it, as if they were both worshipping her and guarding against her."

"Later, I inquired with the old servants in the house and learned that this person was my great-aunt who died young - my great-great-aunt."

Ning Fuyi glanced at Su Mo, who was also looking at her. After the two made eye contact, Ning Fuyi stood up and walked toward where the thing had disappeared.

That was the end of the cellar. The "person" had already vanished, leaving only a pool of blood on the ground that lingered for a long time.

Ning Fuyi raised her hand and drew out the dagger hanging from Qin Xiaoran's waist. Using the handle, she dug toward the blood-stained area. The putrid smell became even more intense, and the mud that was turned up carried a nauseating fishy smell.

Ning Fuyi had to hold her breath while digging. After a long time, she finally dug up something.

It was a coarse cloth handkerchief wrapped around something. Ning Fuyi used the knife tip to pick it out. The handkerchief fell to the ground and scattered, revealing some bone fragments inside.

Qin Xiaoran immediately ran to the side and vomited violently.

Ning Fuyi covered her nose and mouth with her hand, turned to look at Su Mo with a complex expression in her eyes. She threw away the dagger, stood up, and slowly backed away.

She suddenly missed the gardenia fragrance on Chu Qingqiu's body - a scent that seemed able to dispel all the filth of time.

Su Mo looked at the dazed expression in her eyes, her heart sinking for unknown reasons.

But what was even stranger was that when she saw that pile of bones, the fear in her heart that had originally wanted to crush her suddenly lessened, overwhelmed by curiosity about the origin of these withered bones.

So she slowly walked forward, covering her hands with a handkerchief to touch those broken bone pieces. As she touched them, her willow brows slightly furrowed.

"These are human bones, cooked," she turned to Ning Fuyi.

"Cooked?" Ning Fuyi repeated in surprise. Qin Xiaoran, who had just stood up nearby, immediately bent over again and continued dry heaving until he could vomit nothing more, then staggered closer to the two.

Perhaps the physician's sense of responsibility had now overcome her fear of ghosts. Su Mo simply picked up the torn handkerchief and signaled Ning Fuyi to raise the fire starter higher, examining carefully.

After a moment, anger and pity showed in her eyes. Looking up, she saw that terrifying thing had appeared again, crouching in the corner with its decayed head hanging down.

This time, Su Mo looked at it with eyes where fear had faded, replaced more by waves of pity.

"What's wrong?" Ning Fuyi bent down to ask.

Su Mo's movements became much heavier.

"It was eaten by people."

As soon as these words were spoken, Ning Fuyi felt goosebumps from head to toe. She pulled Qin Xiaoran over and repeated Su Mo's words.

Qin Xiaoran was about to faint.

"These bones are delicate and well-proportioned in size. They feel like they belonged to a young person. The pelvis is barrel-shaped - this should be a female child," Su Mo's sign language carried emotion. She finally looked at Qin Xiaoran and suddenly stood up.

For a moment, Ning Fuyi seemed to see Chu Qingqiu.

Su Mo forced Qin Xiaoran to retreat step by step: "Why did your Qin family cook and eat a female child? How are you different from beasts!"

Qin Xiaoran was completely bewildered at this moment, his face completely bloodless. He looked to Ning Fuyi for help: "What is she saying?"

"She's asking why your Qin family cooked and ate a female child," Ning Fuyi also said coldly.

"Cook and eat a female child..." Qin Xiaoran said intermittently, "I, how would I know? These bones clearly date back who knows how long ago. I'm afraid it was my grandfather's generation..."

Speaking to this point, his face suddenly turned blue-black, and he said in a daze: "Grandfather... I remember!"

"I used to hear rumors that my grandfather encountered famine when he was young. At that time, Yangchun Town was still a village. There were three years of great drought, and when they finally managed to grow some grain, they encountered a locust plague. The fields yielded nothing, and the court didn't care. People in the village died of hunger day by day. When they were so hungry... in the end, there were even those who ate people."

"At the time, I only thought people were talking nonsense. Now it seems..." Qin Xiaoran said submissively. He looked toward where "it" was crouching, momentarily speechless.

Ning Fuyi closed her eyes forcefully and asked: "Are you Qin Shumei?"

That mass of "person" slowly nodded.

"Even tigers don't eat their cubs¹. How could they do such a thing!" Su Mo gestured rapidly, and by the end, even her fingertips were trembling.

The "person" shook its head again.

Just as the two were puzzled, Ning Fuyi suddenly spoke: "Exchanging children to eat²."

Feeling Su Mo's gaze, she explained in a low voice: "During times of hardship in the mortal world, when extremely hungry, people would even gnaw on tree stumps. When they were really about to starve to death but couldn't bear to eat their own children, some would exchange children to eat."

That "person" slowly nodded its head, and its bloody mouth opened slightly: "Moth... er."

"Your parents sent you away, but your mother really couldn't bear it, so she collected your remaining bones. However, she didn't dare disobey others by building you a grave and monument, so she could only bury you in this cellar," Ning Fuyi deduced.

It nodded.

She looked at Qin Xiaoran, her gaze cutting across his back like a blade. Qin Xiaoran immediately went weak in the knees and knelt down, his face wet with either sweat or tears.

"How many siblings did your grandfather's generation have?" Ning Fuyi asked.

"Three people. My grandfather was the only male heir. I met my eldest great-aunt when I was young, so this must be my second great-aunt," Qin Xiaoran said while trembling all over.

Ning Fuyi was silent for a long moment, only feeling sighs of sorrow. Perhaps so many years of great joys and sorrows had truly hardened her heart and made her cold. She reached out to pull Su Mo, whose eyes were red with moisture, and said: "This is the Qin family's affair. Let's go."

Qin Xiaoran suddenly prostrated himself on the ground, smashing his forehead into the muddy water and kowtowing heavily several times.

Su Mo was being pulled by Ning Fuyi, looking back every three steps. Suddenly she stopped and stared blankly into the depths of the cellar. She saw that thing suddenly stand up, hanging its hideous and ugly face while stiffly raising its hands that were nothing but bones.

It clumsily gestured "thank you."

Su Mo suddenly covered her mouth, tears bursting from her eyes, and raised her hand: "You're welcome."

"May you enter reincarnation soon and have a complete life next time."

Ning Fuyi first helped Su Mo up to the surface, then climbed up herself. Diagonal raindrops fell on their faces, the sun was hidden behind clouds, and the light was dim.

After this experience, Su Mo seemed to have let down her guard against her and no longer objected to sharing an umbrella. The two walked through the sparsely populated, misty long street toward the outskirts of town.

"What are you thinking about?" Ning Fuyi turned to look at her profile. Although the veil blocked it, Ning Fuyi could imagine through the veil her side face that was more beautiful than the misty rain.

Su Mo originally wanted to say thank you to Ning Fuyi, but she was also worried whether Qin Xiaoran would properly bury the remains. So her gestures became: "Young Master Qin."

The gentleness on Ning Fuyi's face instantly faded, turning to bone-deep coldness. Chu Qingqiu's figure refusing to face her suddenly flashed through her mind. Her heart became agitated, and she actually reached out to grab Su Mo's wrist, spinning her around in a complete circle. The umbrella in her hand also fell into the water with a splash, splashing both of them.

Su Mo cried out softly, looking up into Ning Fuyi's eyes and immediately feeling chilled to the bone. Her already moist eyes were splashed with water again as she struggled desperately with incoherent sounds.

"Do you like him?" Ning Fuyi's tone was cold as winter ice, yet carried interrogation, making Su Mo both anxious and angry.

Unable to break free, she lowered her head and bit Ning Fuyi's hand. Ning Fuyi loosened her grip in pain, and Su Mo retreated like a startled cat.

"What are you doing? I have no feelings for him," Su Mo had never hated her inability to speak as much as she did now, only able to express her anger through ugly guttural sounds.

"I am naturally grateful for your help, but this behavior is truly improper. Why do you question me like this!" Su Mo heavily struck her own hand, then tore off her veil so Ning Fuyi could clearly see her anger.

When that water-soaked, gorgeous skull flower appeared before her, Ning Fuyi felt as if cold water had been poured over her head. She suddenly awakened, and the sound of falling raindrops around them was like beating drums.

She was Su Mo now, not Chu Qingqiu. Chu Qingqiu had done things that Su Mo had never done. Chu Qingqiu knew about her humble feelings, but Su Mo didn't.

Ning Fuyi lowered her head, softly apologized, then bent down to pick up the umbrella from the ground and stuffed it into Su Mo's hands.

Then she wiped her reddened eyes, tossed her hair behind her, and turned to run into the curtain of rain.

Footnotes

1. **Even tigers don't eat their cubs (虎毒不食子)** - A Chinese idiom meaning that even the most vicious creatures won't harm their own offspring
2. **Exchanging children to eat (易子而食)** - A historical term referring to the desperate practice during extreme famines where families would exchange their children with other families to eat, as they couldn't bear to consume their own children